

CAP EXAM AT A GLANCE

Owner	IAAP — Certified Administrative Professional
Items	Approximately 200–225 multiple-choice items; IAAP's published domain-count example totals 200
Time	3 hours
Delivery	Computer-based at an approved testing centre or by online proctoring, subject to current IAAP testing requirements
Blueprint	The CAP Body of Knowledge, built from a job task analysis
Scoring	Scaled scoring with equating across forms; result is pass or fail
Eligibility	Experience scales with education — confirm your own bracket with IAAP

BODY OF KNOWLEDGE DOMAINS

Domain	Weight	Items
Organizational Culture and Leadership	20%	40
Business Communication and Deliverables	16%	31
Software, Data, and the Internet	10%	20
Office and Records Management	17%	33
Meeting, Event, and Project Management	19%	38
Operational Functions	19%	38

TIP Weights are published rounded, so they can total slightly over 100%. Culture and leadership is the single largest domain — study judgement, not just procedure.

ORGANIZATIONAL CULTURE AND LEADERSHIP

- Mission, vision and values drive policy; policy drives procedure.
- Change: explain why, involve people early, train, then reinforce.
- Delegate the task and the authority, keep the accountability.
- Conflict: address it privately and early; collaborate before you compromise.
- Emotional intelligence — self-awareness, self-management, empathy, social skill.
- Confidentiality and professional ethics outrank convenience, every time.

BUSINESS COMMUNICATION AND DELIVERABLES

- Audience, purpose, then medium — pick the channel last.
- Direct order for routine good or neutral messages; for bad news choose direct or indirect organisation to suit the audience, using a neutral buffer when indirect.
- Active voice, one idea per paragraph, headings and white space for scanning.
- Proofread for meaning, then for numbers and names, then for spelling.
- Business letter, memo, email and report each have their own conventions.
- Cite sources and respect copyright in anything you circulate.

PICK THE RIGHT CHANNEL

Situation	Best channel
Sensitive or emotional news	In person, then follow up in writing
Decision needed from several people	Short meeting with an agenda
Record of an agreement	Email or letter
Quick factual answer	Instant message or phone
Detailed data for review	Attached document or shared file

WRITING MECHANICS THAT GET TESTED

- Subject-verb agreement survives phrases between the subject and verb.
- Its is possessive; it's is "it is". Their, there and they're are distinct.
- Use a comma before the conjunction joining two independent clauses.
- A semicolon joins two complete, closely related sentences.
- Keep parallel structure in lists and bullet points.
- Number style varies by style guide — follow the required one consistently; many business styles spell out one to nine and use figures from 10.



OFFICE AND RECORDS MANAGEMENT

- Records life cycle: create, use, store, retain, then dispose or archive.
- A retention schedule — not personal judgement — decides when to destroy.
- A legal hold suspends destruction until counsel releases it.
- Vital records are essential to continuity or recovery, or protect critical legal and financial rights; safeguard them with redundant or off-site copies.
- Index alphabetically unit by unit; "nothing before something" breaks ties.
- Classify records by sensitivity and control access to the confidential ones.

SOFTWARE, DATA AND THE INTERNET

- Spreadsheet basics: SUM, AVERAGE, COUNT, IF, and a lookup function.
- Absolute references (\$A\$1) stay put when you copy a formula.
- Chart by purpose: bar compares, line trends, pie shows parts of one whole.
- Sort and filter before you summarise; check for duplicates first.
- Back up on the 3-2-1 idea: three copies, two media, one off site.
- Phishing, weak passwords and shadow IT are the usual security answers.
- Handle personal data on a need-to-know basis and follow your privacy policy.

MEETING, EVENT AND PROJECT MANAGEMENT

- Agenda out in advance with purpose, times and owners; minutes out promptly.
- Minutes record decisions and actions — not everything that was said.
- Under common parliamentary procedure a main motion is made, seconded, debated and voted; requirements vary by motion, and a quorum is needed to do business.
- Events: define objectives and budget, then venue, catering, AV, then the run sheet.
- Get everything with a vendor in writing, and confirm again close to the date.
- Projects trade scope, time and cost — change one and something else moves.
- Track actions in one visible list with a named owner and a due date.

NUMBERS YOU MAY BE ASKED TO RUN

Budget variance	Actual – budget Read the sign by context: for costs positive is unfavourable, for revenue positive is favourable
Variance percent	$(\text{Actual} - \text{budget}) \div \text{budget} \times 100$
Return on investment	$(\text{Benefit} - \text{cost}) \div \text{cost} \times 100$
Cost per attendee	Total event cost ÷ attendees
Percent change	$(\text{New} - \text{old}) \div \text{old} \times 100$
Price after discount	Price × (1 – discount rate)
Mileage or per diem	Rate × units travelled or days Use the current published rate

OPERATIONAL FUNCTIONS

- Purchase requisition, purchase order, receipt, invoice, then payment.
- Three-way match: purchase order, receiving report, invoice — before you pay.
- Separate who orders, who receives and who pays to control fraud risk.
- Travel: approval first, then booking, then an expense report with receipts.
- Schedule across time zones from a single reference zone and confirm in writing.

TEST-DAY PLAN

1. Budget roughly 48–54 seconds per item depending on your form — keep moving and flag the rest.
2. Choose the professional, policy-following answer over the fastest one.
3. When two answers work, pick the one that consults or informs the right person.
4. Watch for "first", "best" and "except" in the stem.
5. Answer every item; an unanswered item cannot earn a point.

TIP Confirm the current item count, timing and eligibility rules with IAAP before you schedule.

